

CRESTED GLIDER

PTERANODON

The giant, long-crested *Pteranodon* is one of the most spectacular flying reptiles that ever lived. It is known from hundreds of fossils, including some nearly complete skeletons, making *Pteranodon* one of the best-known pterosaurs. The flashy crest on this pterosaur's head, which may have differed in size between males and females, is perhaps its most distinctive feature. It lived near the Western Interior Seaway—an inland sea that divided North America in two during the Cretaceous Period—feeding on fish and other small sea creatures. Like some present-day seabirds, *Pteranodon* would scan the water for prey while swimming on the surface before diving underwater to catch its unsuspecting victim with its long, toothless beak.

At the edge of each wing, *Pteranodon* had three clawed fingers, which probably helped it walk on the ground.

AT A GLANCE

- **WINGSPAN** 20–23 ft (6–7 m)
- **DIET** Fish eater
- **LIVED** 84–71 MYA
- **HABITAT** Oceans



STATS AND FACTS

Like the lungs of modern birds, pterosaur lungs contained air sacs—little growths of tissue that push air into the lungs. These air sacs and the hollow bones of these creatures gave them lightweight bodies, letting the pterosaurs take to the air easily.

WEIGHT



Pteranodon weighed only around 44–88 lb (20–40 kg) due to its hollow bones.

FOSSILS



About 1,100 fossils of *Pteranodon* have been discovered so far.